THE COMFORT PILLS

INDIA'S LONG STRIDES IN THE FIELD OF BIOSIMILARS WILL HELP MAKE QUALITY TREATMENT AFFORDABLE FOR ALL



If there's one health goal that India has persistently focused on in its post-Independence journey, it's extending quality healthcare across the population. But that's a mammoth task considering how a number of diseases require expensive treatments. Among the most promising solutions to this challenge is 'biosimilars', which mimic the active ingredients of a type of drugs called biologics. Isolated from a variety of natural sources, biologics are usually patented. Stem-cell and insulin therapies, and monoclonal antibodies are all examples of biologics. But they are expensive. Against these, biosimilars are a far more affordable option. Not only is India among the few countries today that have access to most biosimilars approved globally, it has also emerged as one of the most competitive destinations for biosimilar research and production. No wonder, since the total number of biotechnology start-ups was estimated at 5,365 in 2021, and this is expected to touch 10,000 by 2024.

WHY IT IS A GAME CHANGER

Biosimilars are produced once a biologic becomes patent-free. Naturally, heavy research and quality control is required to ensure that the biosimilar has the same structure and function as the original biologic. But thanks to the efforts of various companies such as Biocon, Reliance Life Sciences, Dr Reddy's Labs, Zydus Cadila, Lupin and Intas, India is now one of the most reliable players in the arena. According to the journal *Generics and Biosimilars Initiative*, the development of a biosimilar in highly regulated markets, in the EU or the US for instance, is estimated to cost $100–200 million (Rs 833 crore-Rs 1,666 crore). In contrast, in India, the price of developing a similar drug is almost ten times less due to low costs for labour and recruiting patients and conducting trials, as well as cheaper service fee. "Over the past 25 years, our biologics team has developed into a fully integrated organisation with robust capabilities in the development, manufacturing and commercialisation of a range of products in biosimilars. We have a current portfolio of six commercial products marketed in India. We are working on about 11 biosimilars," says a spokesperson from Dr Reddy's.



"The future for the biosimilars market is bright, given its wider acceptance by the medical community, the greater investment in tertiary healthcare, competitive prices, and growing opportunities in export markets"

– K.V. SUBRAMANIAM
Chairman, Reliance Life Sciences